

DUELS IN THE SKY

"THE WHOLE SQUADRON WOULD ENTER the fight in good formation," British pilot Lieutenant Cecil Lewis remembered, "but within half a minute the whole formation had gone to hell. Just chaps wheeling and zooming and diving. On each other's tails... a German going down, one of our chaps on his tail, another German on his tail, another Hun behind that... People approaching head-on firing at each other as they came and then just at the last moment turning and slipping away." This was the classic "dogfight," the result of the meeting of two fighter formations on the Western Front. Committed to a policy of "offensive patrols" over enemy lines, the pilots of the Royal Flying Corps directly invited their German enemies to such combat.

Typically a dozen aircraft of a fighter squadron flew toward the enemy lines in a well-rehearsed close formation, each pilot craning his neck and straining his eyes to pick out distant black specks or a flash of sunlight on a windshield that might reveal the enemy. Whichever side spotted the other first would, if they felt they had the

advantage, maneuver into a favorable position and dive. As Lewis described, the sky then filled with whirling aircraft as the engagement broke up into individual combats. Lieutenant Norman Macmillan recalled: "Our machines could turn in such tiny circles that we simply swerved round in an amazingly small space of air, missing each other sometimes by inches." In this chaos, pilots sometimes shot down or collided with their own colleagues. Guns jammed or ran out of ammunition at crucial moments.

Combat was close up and personal. Macmillan recalled how, as he closed in on a Fokker, the pilot looked around: "I was close enough to see his keen blue-gray eyes behind his goggle glasses... He saw I was dead on his tail and instantly banked and curved to the right... My tracers passed close over his central left wing, just outside his cockpit and in line with his head." Some aircraft returned to base with a film of blood on the

windshield from an enemy shot at close range. Pilots also saw their own colleagues go down, at worst enveloped in flames. Lieutenant Ira Jones recalled being overcome by "a sudden feeling of sickness, of vomiting" as a comrade's machine blazed in the sky nearby.

At the end of a dogfight, pilots often found themselves heading back to their airfield alone, pursued by the enemy. An Australian flier, Lieutenant George Jones, remembered the experience of "being chased without any ability to retaliate" as the most nerve-shattering of all: "Every time I thought of it I could hardly hold a knife and fork if I was having a meal." But most pilots kept a stiff upper lip: according to Lieutenant John Grider, after evading enemy fighters, you "roll in derision as you cross the lines and hasten home for tea."

**"Fighting in the air
is not sport, it is
scientific murder."**

**CAPTAIN EDWARD V. "EDDIE"
RICKENBACKER, USAS**
FIGHTING THE FLYING CIRCUS

PULP HEROES

The dogfights of the Western Front were a popular topic for pulp magazines in the 1920s and 1930s. Colorful pilot memoirs were often combined with outright fiction. Ironically, many pilots later made a living as stunt fliers in Hollywood movies about the romanticized exploits of the aces.



FOKKER SCOURGE

This artwork depicts Lieutenant Oswald Boelcke in a Fokker Eindecker shooting down a British enemy in 1915 — the first victim of Anthony Fokker's synchronized forward-firing system, which allowed the pilot to fire through the propeller blades. It was a great success and allowed Boelcke to lead an aerial reign of terror known as the Fokker Scourge.

